Memory of 518: A Web-Based Platform Connecting Literature, Archival Records, and User-Generated Data

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This study aims to build a literary tour web platform called ‘ *Memory of 518*’, which integrates multi-layered data including literary works and factual records related to the Gwangju May 18 Democratic Uprising (often referred to as 518) of South Korea, along with user-generated data, centering around key historical sites.

The 518 Uprising, a pro-democracy movement that took place in Gwangju in 1980 against military dictatorship, continues to be invoked to date. Interest in the 518 Uprising has increased both domestically and internationally, especially following South Korean writer Han Kang’s Nobel Prize recognition for her novel inspired by the movement, as well as recent political developments in Korea regarding the declaration of martial law. Records related to 518 are not only preserved as UNESCO’s Memory of the World, but also constantly reproduced in literature, media, and public memory. Furthermore, the city of Gwangju itself retains the historical remnants of the uprising, while continuously creating various spaces, cultures, and everyday practices that embody the spirit of 518.

Therefore, to explore the “Memory of 518” accumulated in the unique space of Gwangju—a city that blends past and present, history and literature, everyday life and tourism—it is essential to document and reinterpret 518 using multilateral data that captures Gwangju’s complexity, diversity, and multidimensionality. In this regard, conducting a “tour” based on the multifaceted nature of 518 Gwangju serves as an effective approach.

Although online and offline tour programs operated by Gwangju City currently exist, they have limitations. “Han Kang Literary Tour”, an offline tour program, adheres to visiting the tragic historical spots due to financial and temporal constraints, ending up presenting a partial view of 518 Gwangju, only as a sacred and sad remains. The mobile application “5·18 Democratization Movement Smart Tour” also shows certain shortcomings: lacking interaction with users, providing only “objective” and simplified information, and containing a few factual errors. This project thus proposes a web-based platform, free from spatial and temporal limitations, which offers literary tour courses based on various materials including literature and journals, and encourages user participation in and through the platform as well.

Previous studies have focused primarily on the following areas: the educational effect of literary site visits (Kim Jung-min 2017; Kim Myung-seok 2019), the use of dark tourism for urban revitalization (Jo Hyun-hee 2012; Joo Soo-jung 2016), investigations into the truth of May 1980's Gwangju, critiques of May literatures, and methodologies to teach 518 in history classes (Choi Jung-ki 2016). However, rather than representing the multidimensional nature of "May Gwangju" in an integrated manner, most studies have respectively focused on isolated aspects. As a result, the potential for interconnection between the different facets of 518 remains underexplored. Accordingly, this project aims to depict the fictional, historical, and everyday aspects of 518 Gwangju on the web in a non-linear, multidimensional way through diverse data sources such as literary books, public documents, and contemporary comments.

The literary texts addressed in the project are *Human Acts* (Han Kang 2014) and “A Letter to You” (Hong Hee-dam 1995). Information sources include historical newspaper databases, official government documents from *Modern and Contemporary History Archive*, *Special Exhibition for the 40th Anniversary of the May 18 Democratic Uprising: May, When That Day Comes Again*, etc., and 518-related organizational archives such as *5·18 Archives*, as well as publications like *When That Day in May Comes Again* (Committee for Justice and Peace in Catholic Archdiocese of Gwangju 1987) and *May 18 Democratic Uprising Guide Booklet* (The May 18 Foundation 2021). Key tour spots are selected through literary analysis, and historical documents provide contextual information about those locations and events. Photographs and 360-degree videos provide images of the present-day Gwangju. The web platform

with interactive features is then developed using the React framework, enhanced by visual interactions with the p5.js library, and a user contribution system implemented via Firebase.
Figure 1: An example of the 360-degree photograph offering an immersive and vivid overview of the present Gwangju.

To sum up, the platform consists of two main menus: the Literary Tour and User Participation, both visualized on an interactive map of Gwangju. Firstly, the Literary Tour allows users to trace places featured in literature, providing literary context as well as historical facts and behind-the-scenes stories. Through images and 360-degree views, users experience the reality of those places in the present day and interact with commemorative elements of 518 through simple mouse-based interactions. Secondly, the User Participation section, similar to *Historypin*, allows users to share information about Gwangju's leisure, culture, arts, shopping, dining, and cafés directly on the map. These contributions reveal how current tourists and residents perceive Gwangju along with 518, and serve as a practical guide for those planning an offline visit.

Last but not least, this project is meaningful in that it re-archives Gwangju's past and present through multi-layered data, reframing 518 not merely as a historical trauma but as an evolving memory. The web-based literary journeys also enhance accessibility and engagement of a wider audience, and enrich the user experience. Going forward, the project aims to further develop the platform by incorporating additional literary works and tour courses, while also implementing ongoing user data management.

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